

FANTASY TTRPG

Special Characters for BECMI Rules - - The Bard



Contents

Prime Requisites.....	3
Ability Requirements.....	3
Alignment.....	3
Hit Dice.....	3
Attack Progression.....	4
Attack Rolls (THAC0).....	4
Saving Throws.....	5
Armor & Weapons.....	5
Special Abilities.....	6
Bardic Performance (Inspire).....	6
Countersong.....	6
Lore.....	6
Bardic Appraisal (Identify).....	6
Contacts & Gossip.....	9
Bardic Skills.....	10
Bardic Skills Table.....	10
Spellcasting.....	11
Bardic Spell List (Curated).....	11
Spell Progression (Bard Spell Slots).....	12
Experience & Titles.....	13
Name Level (9th): Bardic College.....	14
Followers & Apprentices (Examples).....	16
Optional Rules & Notes.....	16
Bard at a Glance (Player Aid).....	17

BECMI: Bard (Optional Class)



An itinerant minstrel, silver-tongued envoy, and subtle magician. The Bard mixes agility, lore, and a touch of arcane

craft to hearten allies and beguile foes. An itinerant minstrel, silver-tongued envoy, and subtle magician, the Bard is a master of many trades. This optional class in BECMI combines remarkable agility, a vast repository of lore, and a delicate touch of arcane craft. Bards are renowned for their ability to hearten allies with inspiring songs and cunning words, while simultaneously beguiling foes with illusions and charms. Their versatility on and off the battlefield makes them invaluable members of any adventuring party, capable of influencing the hearts and minds of both friend and foe with their unique blend of performance and magic.

Prime Requisites

Dexterity and **Charisma**. If either score is 13–15 the character gains a +5% experience bonus; if both are 13+ the bonus is +10%.

Ability Requirements

Dexterity 9+, Charisma 9+. No other minimums are required.

Alignment

Any. Many bards prize freedom of movement and story, but courtly traditions exist across all alignments.

Hit Dice

1d6 per level to 9th level; +2 hit points per level thereafter.

Attack Progression

Attack Rolls (THAC0)

Bards use the **Cleric** attack progression. The table below reproduces it for convenience. To determine a hit, roll **d20** and add all modifiers (Strength for melee, Dexterity for missiles, magic, situational). A hit is scored if the result is $\geq (\text{THAC0} - \text{target AC})$.



Bard Level	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14
THAC0 (vs AC 0)	19	19	19	18	18	18	17	17	17	16	16	16	15	15

Example. A 7th-level Bard (THAC0 17) attacks AC 4 with a +1 sword and +1 Strength bonus. Needed roll = $17 - 4 = 13$; after +2 in modifiers, a **11** or higher on d20 hits.

Notes: Bards do not gain extra attacks per round from level alone. Optional rules (e.g., weapon mastery or magic effects) may grant additional attacks; apply those after determining the base chance to hit from THAC0.



Saving Throws

Bards use the Thief saving throw progression. For ease of play, the values are reproduced here. Roll d20; meet or beat the listed number to succeed.

Bard Level	Death/ Poison	Wands	Paralysis/ Petrify	Breath	Spells/ Rods/ Staves
1	13	14	13	16	15
2	13	14	13	16	15
3	13	14	13	16	15
4	13	14	13	16	15
5	12	13	11	14	13
6	12	13	11	14	13
7	12	13	11	14	13
8	12	13	11	14	13
9	10	11	9	12	10
10	10	11	9	12	10
11	10	11	9	12	10
12	10	11	9	12	10
13	8	9	7	10	8
14	8	9	7	10	8

Example: A 6th-level Bard must save vs. a poison needle trap. Death/Poison at level 6 is 12; the player rolls 1d20 and needs 12+ to succeed.

Armor & Weapons

Bards may wear **leather armor** and use **no shield**. Allowed weapons include dagger, short sword, club, hand axe, staff, sling, short bow, and thrown knives/axes.



Special Abilities

Bardic Performance (Inspire)

Use: A Bard may begin a performance **once per day for every two Bard levels** (round down; 1/day at 1–2nd level, 2/day at 3–4th, 3/day at 5–6th, etc.).

Beginning a performance is an action.

Each use may be maintained for up to 1 turn (10 minutes). Allies who can see or hear the Bard gain **+1 to attack rolls** and **+1 Morale** while the performance is maintained; the effect lingers **1 round** after the performance ends. At 9th level the bonuses improve to **+2**. The Bard may not cast spells while maintaining a performance (except for *Countersong*, below).



Countersong

While performing, the Bard and allies within hearing gain **+2 on saving throws vs. charm, fear, and sound-based** effects. The countersong ends if the Bard is silenced, stunned, or drops to 0 hp.

Lore

Bards cultivate tales, heraldry, and half-remembered verses. When confronted with significant persons, places, coats of arms, or magic items, the Bard may attempt a **Lore** check: **20% + 5% per Bard level**. Success yields rumors and general truths (e.g., powers, origins, notable taboos), but does not precisely identify command words or exact powers.

Bardic Appraisal (Identify)

Starting at **3rd level**, a Bard may **appraise a magic item** by recital, symbolism, and careful handling.

Use & Frequency. Spend **1 turn** examining and performing with the item, then roll **d% ≤ Lore**. May be attempted **once per item per day**. The Bard must handle the item directly (gloves are fine); no appraisal during combat.

Roll & Degrees of Success. Determine the **margin** by which the Lore roll succeeds.

- **Failure:** No reliable insight. If the item is **cursed** and the d% is **96–00**, the Bard receives a **misleading rumor** unless a **save vs. Spells** succeeds.
- **Success (margin 0–19):** Learn **one Insight** (choose from the list below). Values are **approximate**.
- **Great Success (margin 20–39):** Learn **two Insights**; one may be **exact** (e.g., “+1” rather than “enchanted”).
- **Master Stroke (margin 40+ or Bard 9th+ with success):** Learn **three Insights**; **two** may be exact. (Never reveals charges or hidden curses outright.)



Insights (choose):

- **Activation hint** (command word style, gesture, rhythm, or usage cue).
- **Property** (one non-harmful function or bonus; approximate or exact per degree).
- **Taboo/quirk** (cost, oath, taboo, or odd behavior tied to the

magic).

- **Tradition/school** (origin symbol, culture, or magic family—e.g., fey glamour, draconic rite, ecclesiastic blessing).



Item Category Guidance. Apply the following clarifications when an Insight pertains to these types:

- **Weapons/Armor:** Property may be exact bonus on Great Success+. Special traits (e.g., vs. undead) are learned as a theme (“hunts the restless”) and become exact at Great Success+.
- **Potions:** Appraise with +20%. Success reveals the **intended spell effect** (approximate; exact on Great Success+). On **00**, a minor side effect occurs (DM’s discretion); no damage from tasting a single drop.



- **Wands/Rods/Staves:** Activation hint typically reveals **gesture/word** and **effect family** (e.g., illumination, compulsion). Charges are **never** learned.
- **Rings & Miscellaneous:** Property is often defensive or constant; appraisal may distinguish between **protection, invisibility, sustenance**, etc.; exact bonus/name only at Great Success+.
- **Scrolls:** Determine **type** (arcane/divine) and broad theme; Bard learns if reading is **safe** for arcane characters (does **not** decode the text; *Read Magic* still required).
- **+10%** known maker, heraldry, or a recorded song/legend of the item.
- **+10%** quiet study with access to a **library or laboratory**.
- **+5%** assisted by a **Magic-User** or **Sage** for the full turn.
- **-10%** item is **cursed**, masked, or bearing conflicting auras.
- **-20%** magic is **alien** to local traditions (DM calls).
- **-10%** rushed: only **5 rounds** of appraisal instead of 1 turn.

Modifiers to Lore (apply all that fit):

- **+10%** item is under *Detect Magic* or text consulted with *Read Magic*.

Suspicion of Curses. When the Bard **succeeds** the appraisal, roll **1d6**: on **1-2**, subtle omens suggest the item is **unsafe** (tainted rhyme, discordant resonance). This grants **+2 on saves** against that item's curse **once** if later triggered.

Progress & Retry. Further attempts on the **same item without new leads** suffer **-10% cumulative** (resets after one week or after meaningful research/performance to gather lore). Changing circumstances (new symbol uncovered, maker identified, access to a library) count as **new leads**.

Research Downtime (Optional). A day spent performing and researching in a town with books or mentors allows **one free re-roll** at **+20%**, but costs **100 gp** in gifts, fees, and ephemera.

Limits (always in effect). Bardic Appraisal never reveals **charges**, full **power lists**, or **curses** directly; those demand testing, divine inquiry, or great magic.

Contacts & Gossip

After performing publicly for an evening in a settlement, the Bard gains **+1 to Reaction rolls** from locals there on the following day and may learn one useful rumor or introduction (DM's choice) tied to current events.





Bardic Skills

Bards learn a **subset** of Thief skills. These skills use the Bard table below and represent light-footed stagecraft rather than full criminal training.

- **Pick Pockets**
- **Move Silently**

Bardic Skills Table

Level	Pick Pockets	Move Silently	Hide in Shadows	Hear Noise (d6)	Read Languages
1	20%	25%	15%	1-2	—
2	25%	30%	20%	1-2	—
3	30%	35%	25%	1-2	20%
4	35%	40%	30%	1-2	25%
5	40%	45%	35%	1-2	30%
6	45%	50%	40%	1-2	35%
7	50%	55%	45%	1-3	40%
8	55%	60%	50%	1-3	45%
9	60%	65%	55%	1-3	50%
10	65%	70%	60%	1-3	55%
11	70%	75%	65%	1-3	60%
12	75%	80%	70%	1-3	65%

- **Hide in Shadows**
- **Hear Noise** (d6)
- **Read Languages** (available starting at 3rd level)

Bards do **not** gain Open Locks, Find/Remove Traps, or Climb Walls.

The DM may grant situational modifiers for careful staging (dim light, cover of crowd, loud tavern, etc.).

Spellcasting

Beginning at **3rd level**, a Bard may cast arcane spells as a **Magic-User of Bard level – 2** (minimum effective caster level 1). The Bard must keep a **spellbook** and prepares spells after eight hours of rest and one hour of study, as a Magic-User. The Bard's spell list emphasizes charm, illusion, insight, and utility.



- **Maximum spell level** is generally **5th** at high Bard levels (owing to the –2 progression).
- **Read Magic** is learned as a 1st-level spell and is required to decipher arcane writings.

- While **performing**, the Bard cannot cast spells except to begin or sustain **Countersong**.

Bardic Spell List (Curated)

1st level: Charm Person, Sleep, Detect Magic, Read Languages, Read Magic, Ventriloquism.

2nd level: Invisibility, Mirror Image, Phantasmal Force, Detect Evil, Detect Invisibility.

3rd level: Dispel Magic, Suggestion, Clairaudience, Clairvoyance.

4th level: Confusion (restricted to 2d4 rounds; save each round), Charm Monster (one target only), Hallucinatory Terrain.

5th level: Telekinesis (reduced weight as DM rules), Feeblemind (requires a full round of focused performance), Passwall.

The DM may freely add thematically similar spells from the campaign's list; if in doubt, prefer charm/illusion/communication over direct damage.

Spell Progression (Bard Spell Slots)

Use this table; it already applies the **Magic-User – 2 levels** rule and **caps Bard spells at 5th level**.

Bard Level	Effective MU Level	1st	2nd	3rd	4th	5th
3	1	1	—	—	—	—
4	2	2	—	—	—	—
5	3	2	1	—	—	—
6	4	2	2	—	—	—
7	5	2	2	1	—	—
8	6	2	2	2	—	—
9	7	3	2	2	1	—
10	8	3	3	2	2	—
11	9	3	3	3	2	1
12	10	3	3	3	3	2
13	11	4	3	3	3	2
14	12	4	4	3	3	3

Notes: Bards begin casting at 3rd level. They never gain **6th–9th level** spells, even if the effective Magic-User level would allow them. The referee may swap equivalent slots across levels only if using house rules that alter the Magic-User table.



Experience & Titles

The Bard advances more slowly than a Fighter but faster than an Elf. Use the table below.

Level	XP Total	Title
1	0	Busker
2	3,000	Minstrel
3	6,000	Jongleur
4	12,000	Troubadour
5	24,000	Court Bard
6	48,000	Skald
7	96,000	Master Bard
8	192,000	High Bard
9	250,000	Name Level — Bardic Maestro
10	370,000	Maestro (10th)
11	490,000	Maestro (11th)
12	610,000	Maestro (12th)
13	730,000	Maestro (13th)
14	850,000	Maestro (14th)

Past 9th level, increase per level by 120,000 XP (DMs may adjust to match the campaign's advancement pace).



Name Level (9th): Bardic College

At 9th level, the Bard may establish a **Bardic College**—a hall, salon, or theater with archives—serving as the Bard’s **stronghold and cultural dominion**. The college recruits talent, hosts salons and festivals, and sustains itself through tuition, performances, and patronage.

Site & Construction. Choose a scale and pay the construction cost; see table. The college requires local permission as any stronghold. Build times assume normal pace (double cost to halve time). Monthly **Upkeep** is **1% of construction cost** (repairs, lighting, instruments, papers) and is paid in addition to staff wages.

College Scale	Construction Cost	Build Time	Staff Wages/Month	Capacity (Apprentices)	Prestige
Modest Hall	25,000 gp	2d6 months	150 gp	6	+0
Conservatory	50,000 gp	3d6 months	300 gp	12	+1
Grand Academy	100,000 gp	4d6 months	600 gp	24	+2

Recruitment & Capacity. Each month the college attracts **1d6 + Prestige** applicants (minimum 1). The Bard may accept any number up to capacity. Accepted applicants become **apprentices**; excess are wait-listed or form a rival troupe. On a **Reaction 10+** with the town’s elite, one applicant that month is a **prodigy** (counts as two students for performances but pays double tuition).

Operations — Monthly Sequence. At the end of each month, resolve in order:

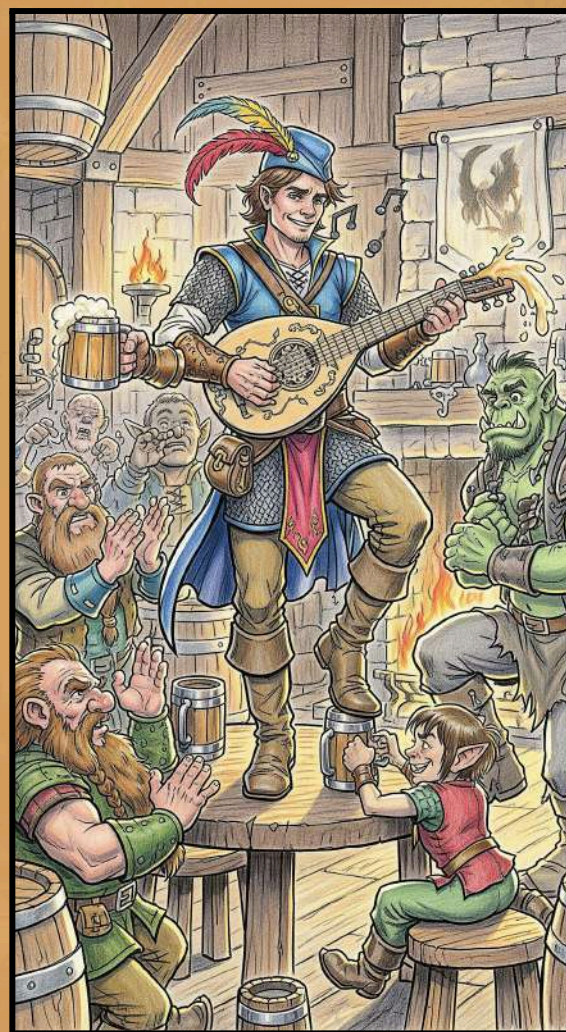
1. **Tuition:** Each apprentice pays **5 gp** (or **10 gp** if the Bard enforces strict standards; reduce monthly applicants by 1 when charging 10 gp).
2. **Performances:** If the Bard spends **1 week** leading events, earn **2d6×10 gp × (1 + Prestige)**;

otherwise **1d6×10 gp**
(representing faculty recitals).

3. **Patronage:** Roll **1d6**; on **6** (or **5–6** if Prestige +2), a patron donates **1d6×100 gp** but expects a favor (DM determines).
4. **Wages & Upkeep:** Pay **Staff Wages** (table) + **Upkeep (1% of construction cost)**.
5. **Net Income:** Tuition + Performances + Patronage – Wages – Upkeep.

Men-at-Arms & Security. The Bard may recruit guards and agents as per dominion rules. A **suggested garrison** is **2 guards per 5 apprentices** (3 gp/month each) and one **captain** (30 gp/month). Theft, jealous rivals, or unruly crowds may target the college when security is light.

Libraries & Archives. Donations (books, maps, instruments) grow the college's archives. For every **500 gp** invested in references, the Bard gains **+10%** to one **Bardic Appraisal** attempt made **on site** (max +30%).



Events & Festivals (d12 monthly): 1: Quiet month (no special effect). 2: Visiting troupe offers joint show; double Performance income this month, split 50/50. 3: Noble wedding; auto-Patronage (treat roll as 6). 4: Scholarly symposium; +1d3 applicants next month. 5: Scandal! Lose 1d3 applicants unless Performance succeeds (earns at least average). 6: Rival school poaches 1d2 students unless the Bard spends a week teaching. 7: Benefactor endows **1,000 gp** to archives (no favor). 8: Bad press; –1 to Reaction locally for a month. 9: Festival season; Performance income is **+1 die**. 10: Theft attempt; check security or lose **1d6×50 gp** of instruments/books. 11: Prodigy

discovered (counts double for performances and pays double tuition).
12: Political request for propaganda piece; gain Patronage but owe a delicate favor.

Benefits. While in the home settlement, the Bard gains **+1 Reaction** with locals,

advantage in rumor-gathering (DM may allow an extra rumor), and counts as having suitable facilities for spell research and **Bardic Appraisal** modifiers described above.



Followers & Apprentices (Examples)

Roll once per month or when the Bard stages a notable festival performance:

- **1-2:** 1d4 educated scribes or copyists (use Normal Human stats).
- **3-4:** 1d4+1 apprentice bards (level 1; treat as Bards but without spellcasting until 3rd level).
- **5:** A traveling troupe (actors, jugglers, animal handler) seeks affiliation; morale +1 while performing under the Bard's banner.
- **6:** A noble patron offers a seasonal stipend in exchange for favors and performances.

Optional Rules & Notes



- **Scroll Use:** At 7th level a Bard may attempt to cast from Magic-User scrolls. There is a **10% chance** of miscasting (DM

adjudicates effects; charm/illusion scrolls are safest).

- **Musical Focus:** A Bard with a signature instrument or style gains **+1 to Reaction** when dealing with those who appreciate that culture (once per locale).
- **Stagecraft:** When the Bard has time to set the scene (dim light,

crowd, music), they gain **+10%** to **Move Silently** and **Hide in Shadows** for the first turn.

Bard at a Glance (Player Aid)

- **Role:** agile supporter & face; battlefield morale and subtle magic.
- **Defense:** leather armor, no shield; d6 Hit Dice; saves as Thief.
- **Offense:** attacks as Cleric; excels at setup and disruption.
- **Utility:** lore, languages, light stealth, curated arcane list.
- **Signature:** performance that sways the flow of battle.



“Every kingdom keeps two histories: one in ledgers, and one in song. Bards read both.”